

the men's 3P spearhead, the issue is also a consequence of India's dependence on foreign manufacturers. He said, "The best ammunitions are with the Europeans, Chinese and Americans. We don't have an Indian maker. So, they will naturally reserve the best for their own." Tomar believes the Chinese have been more proactive in securing supplies, recalling information he received during a previous visit to Lapua's Berlin facility. But he is reluctant to turn the criticism entirely towards the NRAI.

"Honestly, our federation has been trying its best. Now if the makers themselves don't supply, what can the NRAI do? I am still training with old ammo, but I have been told the new lot (from 2025) arrives soon."

Storage troubles

The problem is more complicated than India simply running out of quality bullets. Smallbore ammunition is also highly individual to a barrel. A lot that performs exceptionally well in one rifle may not perform nearly as well in another.

There is also the question of storage. India's humid climate can affect ammunition over time, especially Eley and Lapua ammunition, which are understood to have limited shelf life if not stored in tightly controlled conditions.

Karmakar stressed that simply keeping bullets in an air-conditioned armoury is not enough. He said, "In India, people stress on having the AC on in the armoury. But if the dehumidifier breaks down in the storeroom, no one worries about it. These bullets don't depend on temperature only. Moisture is the real killer. AC without a dehumidifier is even more dangerous."

The former India coach offered a memorable example. "My friend (Sergei Martynov of Belarus) won

three Olympic medals — bronze in Sydney 2000, bronze in Athens 2004, and gold in London 2012. You know where he stored his bullets? In the bank locker so that it remained in a dehumidifier-controlled environment!"



THE ORDER PLACED BY THE NRAI IN JUNE 2025 HAS ONLY JUST REACHED SELECTED ATHLETES IN LIMITED QUANTITIES



Besides oxidation, older pellets may get deformed if stored under pressure. They may develop slightly flattened skirts, damaged heads, and dents around the waist. In 50m, tiny differences almost invisible to the naked eye can become increasingly measurable on the target. Differences in pellet shape or aerodynamics can contribute to both vertical and horizontal dispersion.

There is, however, a silver lining. Satguru Dass, a National Centre of Excellence rifle coach, said Tilottama Sen recently surpassed the world record mark behind closed doors during the Asian Games camp in Bhopal while using 2025 ammunition, the same lot earmarked for use at the Aichi Prefectural General Shooting Gallery in a few days from now.

"They all have tested it themselves. And all of them have shot 93-plus. There is a difference (in the bullets' age), yes, but what we have is good enough. All the ammo which arrived in the first lot was tested again in Bhopal. The best grouping which came was better than what we get for the Olympics. The ammo is old, but it won't make an impact," Dass assured.



Bullet blues: Ashi Chouksey has felt first-hand how an ammunition shortage can unsettle even the steadiest shooter. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Light at the end of the tunnel?

NRAI secretary general Pawan Kumar Singh also offered hope, saying that the federation is actively working with all the ammo manufacturers to make India less dependent on overseas testing and sporadic imports. He said, "The Eley